Identifying logo

This letterhead paper will be used for letters, faxes, press releases



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Reference — ST/BBC

Date — 2 June 2000

Inside address — Mrs Candice Graham
21 Ashley Avenue
Knutsford
Cheshire
KN5 6UT

Salutation — Dear Candice

Heading – give an indication of the content — **FULLY BLOCKED LAYOUT**

The fully blocked method of displaying business documents is now widely used, but do you use it correctly? The main feature of this modern display is that all lines start at the left margin - with no exceptions!

Use a new paragraph for separate ideas or themes (see four-point plan)

Most people combine the fully blocked layout with open punctuation. This means that no punctuation marks are used except in the main body of the message where of course we must use commas and full stops. No punctuation is used in the inside address, date, salutation, complimentary close or enclosure sections.

If you use fully blocked layout for the first page of a letter (or any communication), you must also block the second or subsequent pages. Continuation sheets which start with the page number in the middle are not fully blocked - it should be at the left margin, along with the reference, date and addressee. An example of a continuation sheet displayed in fully blocked layout is enclosed.

I know you will agree that this layout is easy to produce and it looks good too.

Remember to use this layout in all your business documents.

Complimentary close should match salutation — Yours sincerely

Sender's signature

Sender's name and title — SHIRLEY TAYLOR (Miss)

Designation or department — Training Consultant

If anything is enclosed, indicate 'Enc' or 'Encs' — Enc

Use alphabetical order for list of people receiving copies — Copy: James Reeves, Training Manager
Natasha Sirley, Personnel Manager



Fax messages often have their own presentation style (see Unit 9).

Parts of a business letter

Reference

The reference is normally made up of the sender's and the typist's initials. A file or departmental reference may also be included:

ST/lcl ST/MKW ST/HYL/Per134

Date

The date should always be shown in full to avoid confusion. In the UK the date style is presented in the order of day/month/year. No commas are used.

18 August 2000 (18.8.2000)

In some other countries the date is shown in the order of month/day/year, often with a comma.

August 18, 2000 (8.18.2000)

Inside address

The name and address of the recipient should be presented on separate lines as it would appear on the envelope. Take care to address the recipient as they sign their own letters. For example a person signing as Michael Wong should be addressed as such in the inside address, preceded with the title 'Mr'. Make sure you also include a courtesy title, full company name and post code.

✗ Mr M Wong
Aurora Tools
112 Station Road
London SW1

✓ Mr Michael Wong
Aurora Tools plc
112 Station Road
London
SW1A 5BW



The UK post code has two sections separated by a space. Display post codes on a separate line at the end of the address, as they are used to help the post office to sort mail quickly and efficiently.

Airmail/confidential/urgent

Any special indications should be placed between the date and inside address.

CONFIDENTIAL

Mrs Nita Williams
25 Nathan Road
Kowloon
Hong Kong

AIRMAIL

Ms Joelynne Ong
Quest Pte Ltd
154 Jalan Mambong
15320 Kuala Lumpur
Malaysia

Attention line

This is one of the most commonly misused items in today's business correspondence. Traditionally an attention line was used when correspondence was addressed to the company but the writer wanted to ensure that a document was directed towards the desk of a specific person. As such, with the letter being addressed to the company, the salutation was 'Dear Sirs'.

FOR THE ATTENTION OF MR ROBERT WALLACE

Wallace Lighting Ltd
21 Johnson Avenue
Bangor
County Down
Northern Ireland
BT19 6BA

In modern business communications it is rarely necessary to use an attention line. We usually know the name of the person to whom we are writing, so this person's name should be included in the inside address. A personalised salutation will then be used.



HINT

If your boss dictates 'This is a letter to Turners Textiles ... Attention John Low ... Dear John' don't use an attention line! Include John Low's name and designation in the inside address.

Salutation

If the recipient's name has been used in the inside address, use a personal salutation.

Dear Mr Williams Dear Fiona Dear George

If your letter is addressed generally to an organisation, then the more formal salutation 'Dear Sirs' should be used.

Heading

A heading gives a brief indication of the content of the letter. The easiest style is in capitals but with modern computers this could also be highlighted. Headings are usually placed one line space after the salutation.

Dear Mr Low
RESERVATION OF ORCHID SUITE



HINT

Make your heading specific, not vague.

✗ REGISTRATION FOR CONFERENCE

✓ REGIONAL CONFERENCE – 12 AUGUST 2001

Complimentary close

The two most common closes are 'Yours faithfully' which is used with the more formal 'Dear Sir/Sirs/Sir or Madam', and 'Yours sincerely' which is used with personalised salutations such as 'Dear Patrick', 'Dear Mr Ashe'.



HINT

Expressions such as kind regards, best wishes, etc. are not necessary before the complimentary close.

Signature section

After leaving 4–5 spaces for a signature, show the name of the sender in his/her preferred style with the department name or designation directly underneath.

Yours faithfully	Yours sincerely
DOUG ALLEN	Chloe Williamson (Miss)
Financial Controller	Training Manager



HINT

A courtesy title is always shown when the writer is female, but do not include 'Mr' when the writer is male.

Signing on someone's behalf

If you have to sign a letter for someone else, use either of the following suggestions:

Yours sincerely

Sophie Nunn

for JAKE BRADLEY
Chief Executive

Yours sincerely

Sophie Nunn

pp MANDY WILSON (Mrs)
Personnel Manager

per procurationem
(Latin 'through the agency of')

Enclosures

There are many different methods of indicating that something is being enclosed. The simplest and most widely used method is to type 'Enc' or 'Encs' at the foot.

Yours sincerely

GRAHAM LONG
Public Affairs Manager

Encs

Copies

When sending a copy to another person this may be indicated by typing 'cc' followed by the name and title. Traditionally this was an abbreviation for 'carbon copy'. As we rarely have carbon copies these days, 'cc' has become an acronym for 'copy(ies) circulated' or 'courtesy copy(ies)'.

A more modern method is to use 'Copy', as in this example. When sending copies to more than one person, it is better to use alphabetical order.

Copy Monica Gupta, Publicity Manager
Low Chwee Leong, Regional Manager
Teo Lee Kheng, Marketing Manager



Chinese names have the family name first. Hence, 'Low' and 'Teo' are the family names; Chwee Leong and Lee Kheng are first names.

If the sender does not wish the recipient to know that other people are receiving copies, 'bcc' ('blind copy/ies circulated' or 'blind courtesy copy/ies') is used on the copies only, not on the original.

Open punctuation

Open punctuation is commonly used with fully-blocked layout. Only punctuation marks which are essential to ensure grammatical sense are included within the main message itself. All other commas and full stops are omitted.

Dates

✗ 25th September, 2000	✓ 25 September 2001
✗ August 14th, 2001	✓ 14 August 2001



HINT

When you display dates within the body of a communication, make sure you use the same style as you used in the date section. Consistency is essential.

Names and addresses

Mr D S Cowles
Chief Executive
Cowles Publications Ltd
#03-45 Cowles Towers
212 Holland Avenue
Singapore 254367

No full stops
No commas at the end of lines

Salutation

Dear Douglas — No commas

Complimentary close

Yours sincerely — No commas

Abbreviations

✗	Mr.	B.A.	M.R.T.
	Dr.	B.Ed.	I.B.M.
	N.B.	O.C.R.	L.C.C.I.E.B.
✓	Mr	BA	MRT
	Dr	BEd	IBM
	NB	OCR	LCCIEB